

IBM4212 Marketing Problems Syllabus — Fall 2026

Instructor: Dr. Yufan (Frank) Lin

Course Information:

- **Course:** IBM 4212 Marketing Problems
- **Class Schedule:** Monday & Wednesday, 4:00 – 5:15 PM — **In person, Bldg 9, Rm 211**
- **Term:** August 20 – December 6, 2026. **Final Exam: Monday, November 30 — in person, in class (Bldg 9, Rm 211).** The **Teaching Note Report** (team capstone) is due at the registrar-scheduled final-exam slot during finals week (December 7–13, announced on Canvas)
- **First class meeting:** Monday, August 24 (in person)

Office Hours: Monday & Wednesday, 11:00 AM – 1:00 PM — **by appointment (required):** email me to reserve a slot so you aren't double-booked with another student. Zoom appointments available.

Email: yufanlin@cpp.edu (preferred contact method)

- *Please don't hesitate to reach out if you have questions or concerns—I'm here to help. I aim to respond within 24 hours Monday through Friday, and will check messages at my convenience on weekends. I regularly monitor email between 10 AM and 5 PM on weekdays.*

Course Learning Objectives

Are you curious about why the iPhone soared in popularity while its predecessor, the Apple Newton (the inaugural PDA/personal digital assistant), didn't make the mark? Ever wondered why Apple unveiled the Apple Glasses when the highly publicized Google Glass, the first augmented reality headset, couldn't live up to its hype? Interested in understanding how Amazon managed to carve a niche in the lucrative tablet market, a domain Apple established with the iPad, using clever segmentation, targeting, and positioning? Our Marketing Strategy course aims to unravel these mysteries. We'll embark on a journey through time, revisiting real marketing events and famous products or services, creating a parallel universe to explore these intriguing what-if scenarios!

This is fundamentally a course about developing marketing strategies, which is a complex and rewarding process that must take into consideration the ways in which value is created, distributed, and contested in markets. All organizations develop marketing strategies and learning how to think about and create strategies of your own will greatly increase your chances of future career and personal success.

This course focuses on strategically analyzing and solving marketing problems from a decision makers' perspective. Specifically, the course has three key learning objectives:

1. Understanding and effectively using the "first principles" of marketing strategy to solve business problems (fundamental frameworks, processes, and analysis tools of marketing strategy organized under four marketing principles).
2. Co-piloting with Generative AI to solve business problems.
3. Learning by teaching: your team teaches its case to the class — going beyond my recorded discussion — and writes an original teaching note for it, with AI as your preparation partner.

Some critical success factors for business leaders include framing the business issue or problem (frameworks), outlining the steps for solving problems (processes), collecting data and applying analysis tools to inform problems (data collection and analyses), and weighting and integrating information to make choices (decisions). Thus, the overall objective of the readings, lectures, in-class exercises, assignments, and cases will focus on these critical success factors.

Upon successfully completing this course, the student should be able to employ strategic analysis tools, develop and redefine problem-solving and decision-making skills, and demonstrate these skills orally and in writing.

Why AI is Central to This Course

Marketing is the business function being most rapidly reshaped by generative AI. Brand managers, market researchers, and product strategists already co-pilot with tools like ChatGPT every day, and the gap between graduates who can do this well and those who cannot is widening fast. A marketing strategy course that ignores AI in 2026 prepares you for yesterday's job, not tomorrow's.

But — and this is the part students often miss — **AI does not replace strategic judgment; it raises the price of not having it.** Anyone can ask ChatGPT for "a marketing plan." Few can tell whether the plan is any good, why it would or would not work in this market, or which of the first principles it violates. The case method is the perfect proving ground for this dual skill: cases reward judgment under ambiguity, which is exactly what AI lacks. Pairing every case with structured AI use forces you to practice both — frame the problem rigorously *first*, then direct, critique, and integrate what the AI produces.

This semester, AI runs through the course in three ways:

1. **AI-tutored case preparation.** You prepare every case by *talking* with an AI tutor (ChatGPT voice mode, using the starter prompt in each assignment doc) — it quizzes you, challenges your position, and refuses to hand you answers. Your first take comes before AI; the delta between your draft and your final answer is part of what's graded. We practice the entire workflow together, in class, in Week 2 — on the first real assignment, before it's due (bring headphones; you finish your own session at home in a quiet spot).
2. **AI-assisted teaching.** Your team will teach its case to the class — with my recorded case discussion as your benchmark to beat — then extend it with an **AI synthetic-respondent perceptual map** (I demo the method on Amazon in Week 12; you apply it to your case), and write an original **teaching note** built around that extension. Teaching is the strongest test of understanding — and preparing to teach with AI is the co-intelligence skill at its most demanding.
3. **Dedicated AI method lectures, taught live** — the voice-mode workshop (Week 2), the AI-powered perceptual-map extension session (Week 12), and the AI in Business foundation lecture (Week 13), which lands *after* you've co-piloted through five cases and can connect the frameworks to your own experience.

Class Format

Flipped classroom, in person. We meet Monday and Wednesday in Bldg 9, Rm 211. Lectures and case discussions are recorded; class time is for discussion, working, presenting, and debriefing — not for watching me talk at you.

Each case runs a **two-week cycle**:

1. **Before Monday (lecture week):** watch the assigned lecture recording(s) on Canvas.
2. **Monday, in person — quiz + discussion:** class opens with a short multiple-choice **quiz on the recording(s)** (first ~10 minutes, no AI, no notes). Then we work the lecture material together: applications, exercises, and your questions on the slides, and we preview the case.
3. **Wednesday — case workday:** dedicated class time to work on the case assignment — run the voice-mode AI tutor (bring headphones), draft your first takes, build your numbers. I circulate and coach.
4. **Saturday 11:59 PM:** case submission due on Canvas. My **case discussion recording** unlocks Sunday morning — watch it before Monday.

5. **Monday, in person — quiz + debrief:** quiz on the discussion recording, then the case debrief: we compare your positions against mine and each other's, and work the numbers on the board.

6. **Wednesday — the case's team teaches:** the team that owns this case presents — their job is to go **beyond** my recording and Monday's debrief (see Team Teaching Project). The class evaluates them by survey at the end.

The rhythm in one sentence: **Monday, quiz first · Wednesday — weekday or a team presents · cases due Saturday night.**

Prerequisites: IBM 3302 (Marketing Research) & IBM 4112 (Consumer Behavior).

Text book

Textbook (Optional): Marketing Strategy: Based on First Principles and Data Analytics 2nd Edition, by Robert W. Palmatier, Shrihari Sridhar

Harvard Business Case (Required) readings in the form of articles/cases from Harvard Business School Press. Students must purchase the cases immediately if you don't subscribe to the instant access complete. Both textbook and cases are available on Canvas → Sidebar → Instant Access Complete.

Tools

- ChatGPT (voice mode is the recommended case-tutoring workflow — see each assignment doc).
ChatGPT Edu: free access through your CPP email. Office 365 Co-pilot: free access through your CPP email.

Grading

Task	Points
Business Case Discussions (5 × 10)	50
Weekly Quizzes (best 10 of 12 × 5)	50
Team Presentations (class-survey graded: case presentation 12 + extension presentation 8)	20
Teaching Note Report (team capstone)	20
Final Exam	50
Attendance & Participation (iClicker check-in)	10
Total	200

Team Teaching Project (NEW)

In Week 1 you will form **four teams**, and each team is assigned one case (Aldi, Under Armour, Google Glass, or Chunlei). You live through your case's cycle as a student — then you switch sides of the desk, twice. Three deliverables:

Deliverable	What it looks like
1 — Case Presentation: the Wednesday of your case week, in class (15 min + 10 min Q&A; 12 pts)	By the time you present, the whole class has done your case, watched my discussion recording, and sat through Monday's debrief. Your job is to beat that benchmark: the sharpest insight the assignment questions didn't reach, taught fast and well. Every team gets the same setup — my recording is the bar, and going beyond it is what's graded. Dates: Team 1 (Aldi) Sep 23 · Team 2 (Under Armour) Oct 7 · Team 3 (Google Glass) Oct 21 · Team 4 (Chunlei) Nov 4. The class evaluates each presentation by survey at the end of that session.
2 — Extension Presentation: Mon Nov 23, in person (12 min + 3 min Q&A; 8 pts)	In the Nov 9 extension session I demo the method live: perceptual maps built from AI synthetic respondents , applied to Amazon's tablet positioning. Your team then applies the same method to <i>your</i> case — build the map, interrogate your case's positioning with it, and propose the strategy it reveals. All four teams present on Nov 23; class survey at the end. This presentation is the live pitch of your report's extension section.
3 — Teaching Note Report: due at the finals slot (20 pts)	An original instructor's manual for your case, built around your perceptual-map extension : learning objectives, fully worked question analyses (numbers computed, wrong answers diagnosed from the real class debrief), a 50-minute discussion plan, the full AI-synthetic-respondent perceptual-map extension as a runnable classroom activity, and an AI co-authorship appendix. The Dec 2 instruction session walks the structure with a worked example. Full assignment document on Canvas (Module: Team Teaching Project).

How the presentations are graded (12 + 8 = 20 pts). The class rates each presentation on a Google Form on five dimensions; your score on each round is the survey average scaled to that round's points, moderated by me (up to $\pm 10\%$ for observed contribution imbalance, informed by a brief within-team peer-check). Own-team ballots are excluded. Using AI to *prepare* is required and expected; presenting AI-generated slides you can't defend in Q&A — or re-teaching what my recording already covered — is the fastest way to a low survey score.

One integrity rule that matters: the publisher's real teaching notes are instructor-only. Hunting one down — or prompting an AI to reconstruct one — is an academic-integrity violation. Your note is graded on *your* reasoning about *your* classroom, which no leaked document contains.

Why teach? Because it is the strongest form of learning — and because "I wrote the instructor's manual for a Harvard case, with AI as my co-author" is an interview story that outcompetes any line about coursework.

Schedule

Five case cycles, each pairing recorded lectures with a case: **Amazon Kindle Fire** ← P1 All Customers Differ · **Aldi** ← P3 All Competitors React · **Under Armour** ← P2 All Customers Change + Managing Branding · **Google Glass** ← Offering Development + Offering Diffusion · **Chunlei** ← P4 All Resources Are Limited. Case submissions are due **Saturday 11:59 PM**; my case discussion recording unlocks Sunday morning; model answers are released after grading.

Wk	Monday	Wednesday
1	Aug 24 — Course intro (<i>live</i>): why this course runs on experiential learning and AI co-piloting · how the flipped format works · contact sheet · team formation + case assignments. <i>Syllabus practice quiz opens on Canvas this week.</i>	Aug 26 — <i>Live lecture: Marketing Strategy overview — first principles framework</i> (Chapter 1). <i>P1 recording + Amazon assignment + Skill Guide posted this week.</i>
2	Aug 31 — Quiz 1 (P1 recording) · Discussion: All Customers Differ — favorite-retailer heterogeneity exercise, positioning-statement critique (JC Penney) · Amazon case preview	Sep 2 — Voice-mode workshop: set up your AI tutor and walk the full submission workflow together on the actual Amazon Kindle Fire assignment — this is your guided workday (bring headphones; finish on your own at home in a quiet spot). Due Sat Sep 5, 11:59 PM; discussion recording unlocks Sun Sep 6
3	Sep 7 — Labor Day, no class (<i>use the extra day to watch the Amazon discussion recording</i>)	Sep 9 — Amazon Kindle Fire debrief (its recording quiz is Mon Sep 14)
4	Sep 14 — Quizzes 2 + 3 (P3 recording · Amazon discussion recording) · Discussion: All Competitors React — SCA three-purchases exercise · Aldi preview · Team Teaching Project launch Q&A	Sep 16 — Case workday: Aldi. <i>Due Sat Sep 19</i>
5	Sep 21 — Quiz 4 (Aldi discussion recording) · Aldi debrief	Sep 23 — TEAM 1 PRESENTS: Aldi (15 min + 10 min Q&A) + class evaluation survey
6	Sep 28 — Quizzes 5 + 6 (P2 CLV recording · Branding recording) · Discussion: All Customers Change + Managing Branding · Under Armour preview	Sep 30 — Case workday: Under Armour. <i>Due Sat Oct 3</i>
7	Oct 5 — Quiz 7 (Under Armour discussion recording) · Under Armour debrief	Oct 7 — TEAM 2 PRESENTS: Under Armour + survey
8	Oct 12 — Quizzes 8 + 9 (Offering Development recording · Offering Diffusion recording) · Discussion + mid-term course evaluation · Google Glass preview	Oct 14 — Case workday: Google Glass. <i>Due Sat Oct 17</i>
9	Oct 19 — Quiz 10 (Google Glass discussion recording) · Google Glass debrief	Oct 21 — TEAM 3 PRESENTS: Google Glass + survey
10	Oct 26 — Quiz 11 (P4 recording) · Discussion: All Resources Are Limited · Chunlei preview	Oct 28 — Case workday: Chunlei. <i>Due Sat Oct 31</i>
11	Nov 2 — Quiz 12 (Chunlei discussion recording — <i>last quiz</i>) · Chunlei debrief	Nov 4 — TEAM 4 PRESENTS: Chunlei + survey
12	Nov 9 — Extension session (<i>live</i>): perceptual maps with AI synthetic respondents , hands-on, applied to Amazon's tablet positioning — the exact method your team now applies to its own case for the extension presentation and report	Nov 11 — Veterans Day, no class
13	Nov 16 — AI in Business Foundation (<i>live</i>): the frameworks behind everything you've been doing — now that you've co-piloted through five cases	Nov 18 — Guest lecture — and runway to build your extension presentation
14	Nov 23 — EXTENSION PRESENTATIONS (in person): all four teams — your case × AI synthetic-respondent perceptual map + the strategy it reveals (12 min + 3 min Q&A each) + class evaluation survey	Nov 25 — Asynchronous (Thanksgiving week): self-paced final exam review posted on Canvas
15	Nov 30 — FINAL EXAM — in person, in class	Dec 2 — Teaching Note instruction session: report structure walked with a worked example · outline peer swap · course wrap + end-of-term evaluation

Wk	Monday	Wednesday
Fin als	Dec 7–13 — Teaching Note Report due at the registrar-scheduled final-exam slot (announced on Canvas)	

Weekly quiz rhythm: **every recording gets its own 5-point quiz, taken in person at the start of the Monday it's due** — 12 quizzes in total (Aug 31 through Nov 2), multiple-choice, ~8 minutes each. Mondays with two assigned recordings (Sep 14, Sep 28, Oct 12) have two short quizzes back to back. Your best 10 count. Live lectures (Chapter 1, the extension session, AI Foundation, the guest lecture) are not quizzed — but they are final-exam material. The Week 1 syllabus quiz is online practice and unscored.

Method of Instruction

The primary methods of instruction will be case analysis, group work, class discussion, in-class workdays, and student teaching (presentation + teaching note). Lectures are delivered by recording; class time is discussion and application. Class discussions and participation make up a majority of classroom work.

AI Policy

You are required to use generative AI to work through every case. Each Business Case Discussion submission uses the structured workflow built into its assignment document (the fillable Word template on Canvas):

- **Human first.** For each question, you write your first take (Box A, on the Amazon case) *before* any AI touches it, then build your final answer with your AI tutor, then document what changed.
- **Voice-mode tutoring is the recommended workflow** — attach the case PDF, paste the starter prompt from the assignment doc, and *talk* through the questions. Prefer typing? The same prompt and rules work in a text chat.
- **What's graded is substance, not prompt count:** at least **3 substantive exchanges per question** — your positions, follow-ups, and pushbacks. Stating the assignment question to set the agenda is fine; it just doesn't count as an exchange.
- **Name what you rejected.** At least one AI suggestion you overrode, with the reason. Negative cases are where your judgment shows: "AI claimed X; I checked the case and went with Y" beats ten clean prompts.
- **A working transcript link** (share link, not a pasted dump) is required with every submission. Voice transcripts read like conversation — that's a feature: they are your integrity record. Fishing for answers after the tutor refuses is visible in the transcript and graded down.
- **Generative AI is NOT permitted during quizzes or the Final Exam.** It is required for case work and team-teaching preparation only.

Each case's **Skill Guide** (released with the assignment) shows what strong exchanges and strong answers look like; **Model Answers** (including a model first take and delta log) are released after grading.

Attendance, Participation, and Professionalism

iClicker

Attendance is recorded through iClicker at each class meeting. One-time setup — **your iClicker subscription is already included in Instant Access Complete, so do not buy one separately:**

1. **Get your access code.** On Canvas, open **Instant Access Complete** in the course sidebar, find **iClicker Student Mobile (Six-Months Online)**, and click **View Details** to reveal your access code.
2. **Create your account** on the iClicker student app (Apple or Android; desktop version at iclicker.com if you don't have a smartphone) **using your full name as shown on Broncos Direct.**
3. **Redeem the code.** In the app: menu (top left) → **Subscriptions** → **Enter Access Code** → enter the code from step 1.

4. **Add the course.** Search for "California State Polytechnic Univ Pomona" → "IBM4212 Marketing Problems - Lin" → Add Course.

Zoom-chat participation pilot (first weeks). In parallel with iClicker, we are piloting a second attendance method for the first few class meetings: join our class Zoom session **from your seat** (Canvas sidebar → Zoom; sign in with your **CPP Zoom account**, stay muted, speaker off) and answer the 1–2 quick questions I post during class **in the Zoom chat**. A typed answer is active-participation evidence, not just a button press — and being in the session also lets you **share your screen** during workdays and presentations. iClicker remains the attendance method of record during the pilot; if the pilot works, we will switch fully to Zoom chat, announced on Canvas.

First Lecture Attendance Policy: Per Cal Poly Pomona's policy, students who miss the first lecture will be dropped to make room for waitlisted students. Additionally, failing to complete the contact sheet by the end of the first class will result in being dropped from the course.

Regular attendance and active participation are essential — a flipped course runs on what happens in the room, and on presentation Wednesdays you are the presenting team's survey graders. You are allowed **two absences** without penalty. Each additional unexcused absence reduces your attendance score by 25% of its value. Illness-related absences are excused with notification or a doctor's note. Tardiness equals absence; class times are determined by the classroom clock.

Students must maintain professional behavior during class, including arriving on time, showing courtesy to classmates and instructor, being reliable in team preparation, and meeting standard student and employee conduct expectations. **Your team's presentation days (the Wednesday of your case week, and Mon Nov 23 for the extension round) are professional commitments:** missing your own team's presentation without an excused absence scores zero on that component's individual share.

Examinations

There will be one final exam (mixture of multiple choice, true-false, and short answers), given **in person, in class, on Monday, November 30**. It assesses familiarity and understanding of marketing strategy concepts and practices. You are responsible for all recorded lectures, all live lectures (including the extension session, AI Foundation, and the guest lecture), everything covered in class (including team presentations), and the assigned text and cases. A self-paced review is posted over Thanksgiving week (Nov 25). During finals week there is no sit-down exam; your team's **Teaching Note Report** is due at the registrar-scheduled final-exam slot.

Quiz & Exam Rules

Weekly quizzes are taken **in person at the start of Monday classes** (on Canvas — bring a charged laptop, tablet, or phone). Each assigned recording gets its own 5-point quiz; on two-recording Mondays the two quizzes run back to back. Arrive on time: quizzes run in the first minutes of class and cannot be made up if you miss them — that's what the two dropped scores are for. The Final Exam (Mon Nov 30) is in person, in class, on Canvas. During every quiz and the Final Exam:

1. **Stay in the Canvas quiz tab.** Canvas logs every time the quiz page loses focus — every tab switch and window change, with timestamps.
2. **Work alone, with no outside resources** unless I explicitly identify the quiz/exam as open-resource. **No generative AI.**
3. **No phones-as-second-screens, no earbuds/headphones** during the quiz or exam window, unless an approved DRC accommodation specifies otherwise.

Consequences of a flagged submission: zero on that quiz/exam, and an Academic Integrity report filed per CSU Standards for Student Conduct. **If technology fails mid-quiz:** show me immediately, in the room; do not

silently resubmit.

Case Preparation and Late Submissions

All cases assigned are based on actual marketing management issues. The case study approach allows students the opportunity to assume the role of a marketing manager faced with the challenges and opportunities in a competitive marketplace.

Late Submissions: Time management is a key skillset you'll need throughout your career. Late submission will not be accepted and results in a grade of zero. Case submissions are due **Saturday 11:59 PM** and gate the debrief week — the discussion recording unlocks Sunday for everyone, Monday's quiz covers it, and the case quiz assumes you did the work. No submission, no Business Case Discussion credit. If you inform me ahead of the due date with legitimate reasons, I might judge and accommodate a few days of extension.

OTHER CPP POLICIES, STUDENT SUPPORT & RESOURCES

Communication:

Your CPP email account is the official means of communicating with the university. Any email from you to the instructor should be sent through your official CPP email account. Please be advised that due to privacy and security concerns, I am unable to respond to emails from or about students that do not originate from an official university email address.

Excused Absences:

Excused absences include the following situations listed below. Authorized absences do not relieve the student of class responsibilities. Written documentation of the authorized absence (including the date/time) must be provided to the instructor for the opportunity to make up missed assignments.

Student participation in authorized activities as an official representative of the university (i.e. athletic events, delegate to regional or national meetings or conferences, participation in university-sponsored performances).

Participation in other activities deemed by the Dean of Students to warrant an excused absence, such as required military training.

An extreme personal emergency or serious medical condition.

The death of an immediate family member (such as parent, sibling, spouse or child).

Student participation in religious holidays.

Accommodation Requests:

I encourage students with disabilities to visit me privately during office hours during the first week of the semester to discuss appropriate accommodation needs during lectures and exams. You should also contact the Disability Resource Center (Bldg 9, Rm 103) to register as a student with a documented disability, and to coordinate your testing accommodation needs with me.

Academic Integrity Notice:

Academic integrity is essential to the educational process. The value of an academic degree is based upon the reputation of the university. Academic dishonesty, which includes plagiarism or cheating, is a serious offense. Students are responsible for understanding and complying with California State University Standards for Student Conduct that are available on the website of the Office of Student Rights & Responsibilities.

Dishonesty results in an immediate zero on that assignment with no chance for make-up. All forms of academic dishonesty will be registered with Judicial Affairs.

Bronco Dreamers Resource Center:

Supports the holistic success (academic, personal, professional) of undocumented students at Cal Poly Pomona. Our purpose is to educate the community about current issues and to convene campus allies in a dialogue of student success.

Counseling & Psychological Services (CAPS):

Provides quality mental health services to support your overall health and wellbeing. CAPS provides many services such as workshops, group or individual therapy, wellbeing coaching, crisis intervention, and support to access on- and off-campus resources.

Disability Resource Center (DRC):

Provides students with Test Accommodations, Notetaking Services, Alternate Media, Modified Attendance, Deaf and Hard of Hearing Services, Mobility Assistance, Housing Accommodations, Student Success Coaching, and Peer Mentoring.

EWS Subject Librarian:

EWS Research Guide: <http://libguides.library.cpp.edu/ews> Sally Romero, [sallyromero@cpp.edu](<mailto:sallyromero@cpp.edu>)

Inclusive Excellence:

The role of Inclusive Excellence is to work with the campus community to ensure that Cal Poly Pomona's core institutional values of diversity and inclusivity are deeply embedded in every aspect of our community.

Institutional Equity and Compliance:

Oversees the University's compliance with Federal and State laws and regulations and CSU System policies. Part of this compliance includes overseeing reports and investigations of prohibited conduct, including: discrimination, protected status, retaliation, Whistleblower Protection Act, dating and domestic violence, and stalking; sexual misconduct, consensual relationship, and religious accommodation. Office of Institutional Equity & Compliance (OIEC).

University Ombuds:

Contact the Ombuds Office for concerns about, not limited to interpersonal conflicts, disagreement over grades, working conditions, clarification of policies or procedure, or co-worker difficulties.

Learning Resource Center (LRC):

The LRC is the University's most comprehensive tutoring service, promoting the development of students' critical thinking, problem solving, and analytical skills through Academic Skills Coaching, Subject Tutoring, Supplemental Instruction, and the Writing Center.

Office of Student Life & Cultural Centers:

Includes Clubs and Organizations, Fraternity and Sorority Life, Leadership Development, African American Student Center, Asian and Pacific Islander Student Center, Cesar E. Chavez for Higher Education, Native American Student Center, Pride Center, and Womxn's Resource Center.

Student Health & Wellness Services:

Health Educators and Peer Health Educators provide Cal Poly Pomona students with health education to prevent the development of chronic conditions. Wellness Services provides resources and programs dedicated to various health topics including but not limited to nutrition, sexual health, mental health, physical activity, sleep, and stress management.

Student Support & Equity Programs:

Student Support and Equity Programs (SSEP) aspires to offer model programs and services that continuously evolve to meet the changing needs of our diverse students.